

ACME Health Plan - Coverage Policy Document

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Musculoskeletal Imaging Authorization Policy

Policy Number: MSK-IMG-2024-001 | Effective: January 1, 2024

1. PURPOSE

This policy establishes prior authorization requirements for musculoskeletal imaging services, including MRI, CT, and X-ray studies of the spine, joints, and extremities.

2. DEFINITIONS

Conservative Treatment: Non-surgical treatment including physical therapy, chiropractic manipulation, and pharmacologic management for a minimum of six (6) weeks.

Red Flag Symptoms: Clinical findings warranting immediate imaging without prior conservative treatment, including cauda equina syndrome, severe neurological deficit, fracture, malignancy, or infection.

3.1 Low Back Pain - Lumbar Spine MRI (CPT 72148, 72149, 72158)

Authorization approved when ALL criteria met:

- a) Confirmed diagnosis of low back pain (ICD-10: M54.5).
- b) Minimum six (6) weeks of conservative treatment completed.
- c) Provider notes with dates of service documented.

EXCEPTION: Waived for members with red flag symptoms.

3.2 Cervical Spine MRI (CPT 72141, 72142, 72156)

Authorization approved when:

- a) Cervical radiculopathy (ICD-10: M54.12) or myelopathy (ICD-10: M47.812) diagnosed.
- b) Four (4) weeks conservative treatment completed.
- c) Neurological examination findings documented.

3.3 Knee MRI (CPT 73721, 73722)

Authorization approved when:

- a) Ligament tear (ICD-10: S83), meniscus tear (ICD-10: M23.2), or osteochondral defect diagnosed.
- b) X-ray performed within prior 12 months.
- c) Four (4) weeks of physical therapy completed.

4. DOCUMENTATION REQUIREMENTS

Providers must submit:

- PA request form with member ID and date of birth
- Clinical notes with diagnosis and treatment history
- Conservative treatment records with dates
- Ordering physician NPI number

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Incomplete requests returned within two (2) business days.

5. AUTHORIZATION TIMEFRAMES

Standard requests: three (3) business days.

Expedited requests: one (1) business day when delay jeopardizes member health.